The MPR Community

Model. Printer. Robot. What Remains?

I recently read an article about the impact of AI on labor. The article was titled "CEOs Start Saying the Quiet Part Out Loud: AI Will Wipe Out Jobs", and you can read it here. It's an interesting perspective, and I encourage you to read it for yourself.

If you're like me, you may have gravitated toward the quote from Ford CEO Jim Farley: "Artificial intelligence is going to replace literally half of all white-collar workers in the U.S." That got me thinking: why only half?

In that vein, I'd like to test the boundaries of what's possible. I'd like to create a thought experiment and push this technology-driven future a bit farther.

Consider a small community of individuals with:

1. A sufficiently large plot of fertile land
2. A supply of potable drinking water
3. Access to raw materials from a larger external community (e.g. a nation-state)

With those in place, three additional technologies are introduced:

1. An AI model capable of creating a better AI model
2. A 3D printer capable of printing a better 3D printer
3. A robot capable of assembling a better robot

If a community has these six things, how many jobs would actually be required?

I asked an AI model to generate a list of the top 100 professions in the world. And from that list, I asked it to say which ones would clearly be unnecessary in the above scenario. To my surprise, it only eliminated 20 of them. So I asked it to list the top five most resilient and critical jobs that remained. It came up with the following list:

1. Systems Infrastructure Engineer
2. AI Safety / Security Steward
3. Physician
4. Governance Authority (Judge/Executive)
5. Skilled Infrastructure Technician (Electrical/Mechanical)

I then proceeded to push back on the remaining professions. Not because I believe all human work should disappear, but because I wanted to understand how much of what we currently call work is truly permanent, and how much of it is simply toil that exists because our tools are still limited.

Physician seemed fairly interesting, so I selected that as the first profession for consideration. My dialog with the AI model went something like this:

`Me:` Let's explore the physician. If I have a robot that can perform surgery, and a model that understands all of the latest techniques, and every necessary medical instrument can be 3D printed, then why do you claim I need a physician?

`AI:` You don't need a physician-as-proceduralist, but you need a medical authority for things like value tradeoffs, end-of-life decisions, etc.

`Me:` Why must a physician make those decisions? It seems like an ethical human would suffice. They could ask for expertise from the model, and draw on the unique needs of the community.

`AI:` (After some additional clarifications) A physician is not necessary. A human legitimacy role is still necessary.

Okay, one down. Now, let's move on to the Systems Infrastructure Engineer.

`Me:` I am most surprised by your entry of Systems Infrastructure Engineer. Honestly, given an "ethicist", I can't think of a single reason to need one. Please use the previous dialog about a physician as a template to have your own internal back-and-forth conversation and tell me if you agree.

`AI:` (Again, some additional back and forth.) Systems engineer, as a profession, is not strictly necessary; a human accountability / constraint role might be.

`Me:` So, in other words, the exact same role that replaced the physician?

`AI:` Yes. Under your assumptions, it collapses to the same role.

Once it observed the pattern, I asked it to reevaluate the entire list. To my surprise, the model came to the following conclusion:

Brief Summary of Findings

Under your assumptions:

- Every previously "critical" technical profession collapses.
- AI + robotics eliminate the need for human technical operators.

What remains is one irreducible function:

- A human legitimacy / constraint-setting authority.

If you accept:

- AI can self-monitor,
- AI can self-repair,
- AI can self-validate,
- AI can self-improve safely,

Then no specialized human profession is technically required.

The only remaining human necessity is:

- Moral authority
- Collective legitimacy
- Accountability embodiment

And even that disappears if the community accepts full machine sovereignty. Everything else is optional.

That is a striking conclusion. But to me, it is interesting for a reason slightly different from the one that first grabbed my attention.

The point is not merely that professions may collapse under sufficiently advanced automation. Plenty of people wave their hands and say that. What matters is being willing to pick a few supposedly indispensable professions and ask, in concrete terms, what actually remains once procedure, maintenance, fabrication, and optimization can all be delegated to machines.

And when you do that, a different possibility comes into view.

The real question may not be whether all human work disappears. The more interesting question is whether **work as toil** begins to disappear.

By toil, I mean the sort of work that is repetitive, burdensome, compulsory, and largely instrumental. The work people do not because it is intrinsically meaningful, but because someone has to do it. The work required to keep systems running, to maintain a convenience store, to repair limits in human memory, strength, speed, and coordination. Historically, a very large share of human labor has fallen into this category.

Enjoyable and rewarding work is something else entirely. Communities may still choose to heal, teach, govern, build, create, explore, invent, care for one another, and make art. But there is an enormous difference between doing those things because they are meaningful and doing them because survival or social participation leaves no alternative.

If that distinction matters, then the implications of this thought experiment are significant.

Yes, one implication is that many present-day professions may shrink or collapse. Yes, another implication is that large organizations may not be as necessary as they once were, at least for some functions. But those are secondary observations. The primary one is that a sufficiently capable combination of AI, robotics, and self-improving tooling may dramatically reduce the amount of undesirable labor required to sustain a decent life for a small community.

That changes the question.

Instead of asking, "Which jobs survive?", we may eventually need to ask, "How much obligatory toil is truly left?"

Going back to the quote from Ford's CEO, we're left wondering about more than whether companies need fewer people. We may eventually find ourselves wondering whether people need far less from companies than they once did.

To make that more concrete, let's use Ford as an example. If I have a need for a truck, then why would I go through all of the trouble of procuring a generic one that marginally meets my needs, when I could simply print and assemble a purpose-built "truck-like-vehicle" instead? And when I'm done with it, I can scrap it and harvest back out the raw materials. I can then reuse those materials to print and assemble something else.

In that context, Ford does not merely become less central as an employer. It may become less necessary as an intermediary. But again, that is not the main point. The point is: a community that can produce what it needs with minimal human drudgery has changed its relationship to labor itself.

Quite frankly, this seems like a short-term concern compared with what follows. Once you start truly exploring this thought experiment, countless questions emerge. In fact, so many questions that it feels a bit overwhelming. It's forced me to step farther back and contemplate two basic questions:

1. Is the premise of this essay reasonable? And if so, how soon would this be possible?
2. Once much of necessary toil is eliminated, what remains for humans to do? In other words, what becomes our purpose?

Many interesting avenues of exploration open up:

- Do entertainment, pleasure, amusement, and self-fulfillment become more central?
- Can entertainment, culture, meaning, and purpose become far more localized?
- What should humans do with all of the time reclaimed from professional toil?
- What happens when work becomes more optional, more chosen, and less tied to survival?

Admittedly, the technological premises in this essay do not exist today. And it may be a very long time before they do. There may also be significant scaling issues, if scaling is even desired by the community. Nonetheless, it is difficult to argue that such a future is impossible.

If progress continues along its current trajectory, it may become harder to dismiss.

And if so, then perhaps the real challenge is not simply preparing for job loss. Perhaps it is preparing for a world in which human life is organized around something other than toil.

Of course, there are countless implications for how this community would interact with the rest of the country. Many different approaches seem feasible. So many, in fact, that it probably merits its own essay. But regardless of the underlying social structure, the technical feasibility of an "MPR" community seems like an eventuality, not an untouchable dream. Only time will tell, but I remain interested in developments which help make this possible.